



WAR IS DECLARED! DOWN WITH MONITORS AND PUNISHMENT!

ZERO DE CONDUITE / 1933

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Surrealist comedy

DIRECTOR

Jean Vigo

WRITER

Jean Vigo

STARS

Jean Dasté, Louis Lefebvre, Coco Golstein

BEFORE

1924 René Clair's Surrealist short, *Entr'acte*, plays with the frame rate to produce a spooky slow-motion effect.

1929 Director Luis Buñuel teams up with artist Salvador Dalí to make the Surrealist movie *Un Chien Andalou*.

AFTER

1934 Vigo's only full-length movie, *L'Atalante*, tells the poetic story of a newly married couple living on a barge.

1968 Lindsay Anderson's *If...* depicts a rebellion in a British public school.

Jean Vigo's 41-minute *Zéro de Conduite* (*Zero for Conduct*) caused both outrage and delight when it premiered in Paris in April 1933. But although its anarchic spirit was deplored by the Establishment (it was banned by the French Ministry of the Interior until 1946), with hindsight the movie isn't really all that political, at least not in the way that the authorities first perceived it.



On its release, *Zéro de Conduite* provoked strong reactions against its irreverence for conventional sensibilities. It was banned in France until 1946.

Zéro de Conduite is perhaps best seen in the context of French Surrealist cinema, following in the tradition of

René Clair and Luis Buñuel, who threw narrative sense out the window, juxtaposed random images, and often morphed into strange scenarios with bizarre dialogue. These were serious works of art, aiming to explore the subconscious, yet also simply irreverent.

A child's-eye view

The movie was funded by a private patron, who paid Vigo to create a story based on his childhood experiences of boarding school. This was not to be a nostalgic trip down memory lane for the director, but an attempt to recreate the state of being a child. Some of the movie's rough

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One of the most poetic films ever made, and one of the most influential.

Pauline Kael

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